

PERSONAL READING SERIES

BUDDHISM

A Complete Overview

*Theravada, Mahayana, and Vajrayana —
The Three Vehicles of the Awakened Mind*

*A prince left his palace and sat under a tree.
What he found there became the second largest religion on earth
and one of the most sophisticated maps of consciousness
ever produced by a human mind.*

*This document is the parent text.
Tibetan Vajrayana and Japanese Shingon
branch from here.*

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INTRODUCTION

The Second Largest Religion on Earth

Approximately 500 million people identify as Buddhist — making Buddhism the fourth largest religion in the world by nominal affiliation and arguably the second most influential in terms of its impact on global philosophy, art, psychology, and contemplative practice. Unlike Christianity or Islam, Buddhism did not spread through military conquest or state coercion. It spread through persuasion — through the quality of the teaching itself, the visible transformation of practitioners, and the capacity of Buddhist philosophy to engage and enrich every culture it encountered without demanding that culture abandon its own sacred framework.

Buddhism is not one thing. Across twenty-five centuries and dozens of countries, it has produced a range of forms so diverse that a Theravada monk in Myanmar and a Zen practitioner in California and a Tibetan tantrika performing deity visualization in Dharamsala and a Pure Land practitioner chanting Amitabha's name in Tokyo are all, technically, practicing the same religion — though the surface appearances of their practice have almost nothing in common.

This document is the parent text for Buddhism in the Haligricity library. It covers the historical foundation, the core philosophical teachings, the three major vehicles, the spread across Asia, and the Haligric lens. Two companion documents — Tibetan Vajrayana and Bon, and Japanese Shingon Buddhism — cover those specific traditions in the depth they deserve. This document gives the complete map from which those traditions branch.

THE HISTORICAL BUDDHA — WHAT SCHOLARS ACTUALLY KNOW

Siddhartha Gautama was born in Lumbini — in present-day Nepal, near the Indian border — most likely sometime between 563 and 480 BCE, though the exact dates remain debated among scholars. He was born into the Shakya clan, a small republic in the foothills of the Himalayas, to a family of the warrior-noble (kshatriya) caste. His father Suddhodana was a chief or king of this clan — though the traditional title 'king' overstates his political status, which was closer to an elected magistrate of a small territory.

The biographical accounts of the Buddha's life were compiled centuries after his death and contain legendary elements that most scholars distinguish from the historical core. What the historical record most confidently supports: a man named Siddhartha Gautama lived in northeastern India, renounced a life of privilege, practiced intensive asceticism, rejected extreme asceticism, sat in meditation under a specific tree, reported a transformative experience of awakening, spent approximately forty-five years teaching across the Ganges plain, gathered a substantial community of monks and nuns and lay practitioners, and died at approximately eighty years of age in Kushinagar.

The legendary elements — the miraculous birth, the thirty-two marks of a great being, the previous life stories (Jataka tales), the cosmological scope of the awakening — were added progressively across the centuries and reflect the living tradition's understanding of what the Buddha represented rather than biography in the modern sense. Both layers — the historical person and the legendary figure — are present in the tradition simultaneously, and different Buddhist schools weight them differently.

What is not disputed: Siddhartha Gautama lived, taught, and produced a body of oral teaching preserved and transmitted by his disciples that represents one of the most sustained, internally consistent, and philosophically rigorous investigations of the nature of mind, suffering, and liberation ever undertaken by a human being.

◆ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The historical Buddha is a figure whose reality is confirmed by independent sources — including Jain texts that describe encounters with the 'wanderer Gotama' — and whose teaching is corroborated in its essentials across multiple independent early textual traditions. He was a human being who achieved something the tradition calls awakening and spent his life teaching others how to do the same. This is the Haligric understanding: not a god who descended but a human being who went all the way in, and came back to show the way.

The traditional account of Siddhartha's awakening begins with the Four Sights — the encounters that broke open his understanding of human life. Raised in luxury and sheltered from suffering by his father, the young prince encountered successively an old man (the first sight of aging), a sick man (the first sight of illness), a corpse (the first sight of death), and a wandering ascetic (the first sight of a person who had chosen to confront these realities directly). These encounters produced what the tradition describes as a profound existential crisis — the recognition that wealth, pleasure, and social position provided no protection from the fundamental conditions of human existence.

At approximately twenty-nine years of age, Siddhartha left his palace, his wife Yasodhara, and his newborn son Rahula in the night and began the life of a wandering seeker — the Great Renunciation. He studied first with two accomplished meditation teachers: Alara Kalama, who taught him to reach the state of nothingness in meditation, and Uddaka Ramaputta, who taught him to reach the state of neither perception nor non-perception. Siddhartha mastered both states but found them insufficient — they produced profound peace during meditation but did not address the root of suffering when the meditation ended.

He then joined a group of five ascetics and practiced extreme physical self-mortification for approximately six years — reducing his food intake to almost nothing, exposing himself to extreme heat and cold, holding his breath until he nearly lost consciousness. The traditional accounts describe him as becoming skeletal, his spine visible through his abdomen. He eventually concluded that extreme asceticism was not the path — that a body pushed to the edge of death could not support the clarity of mind required for genuine investigation. He accepted a bowl of rice milk from a young woman named Sujata, recovered his strength, and sat down under a fig tree near the town of Bodh Gaya.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: The Middle Way — Siddhartha's rejection of both sensual indulgence and extreme asceticism — is the foundational Haligric teaching in Buddhism. The body is not the enemy of awakening — it is the vehicle. Destroying the vehicle does not reach the destination. Tending the vehicle with the wisdom of the Middle Way does. Every practice in the Haligric Well-Being book operates from this understanding.**

Siddhartha sat under the Bodhi tree (a species of fig, *Ficus religiosa*, now called the Bodhi tree — the tree of awakening) and resolved not to rise until he had found what he was seeking. The traditional account describes a night of profound psychological and spiritual encounter — the assault of Mara (the principle of delusion and death, comparable to the tempter figures in other traditions) and its defeat through the simple act of touching the earth — calling the earth to witness his right to awakening through the merit of his long practice.

As the night progressed, the accounts describe three distinct phases of insight: in the first watch of the night he perceived his own previous lives across countless existences; in the second watch he perceived the workings of karma — how actions condition future existence across the cycle of death and rebirth; in the third watch he perceived directly the nature of dependent origination — how all suffering arises through a specific chain of conditions, and how the liberation from suffering requires the understanding and cessation of those conditions.

What the Buddha achieved under the Bodhi tree is called in Sanskrit Bodhi (बुद्धि) — awakening, enlightenment. The word Buddha simply means 'the awakened one' — from the root budh, to wake up, to know, to understand. Siddhartha Gautama became the Buddha at that moment — not by receiving a divine gift, not by being designated by a god, but by understanding something about the nature of reality so completely that the fundamental misunderstanding that drives suffering was permanently dissolved.

*Just as a lotus rises from the mud to bloom in sunlight, we too can
rise from difficulty and radiate into the world.*

*"Three things cannot be long hidden: the sun, the moon, and the
truth."*

"Peace comes from within. Do not seek it without."

— Teachings attributed to the Buddha

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Haligric reading of the awakening is precise: Siddhartha did not become something he was not before. He recognized something that was always already true — the nature of his own mind, the structure of suffering, and the path through it. This is the same recognition that Advaita Vedanta calls the recognition of Atman as Brahman, that Taoism calls returning to the Tao, that Sufi tradition calls fana. Different vocabularies. The same moment of recognition.

THE FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS — THE COMPLETE TEACHING

The Four Noble Truths (Catvari Aryasatyani) are the structural foundation of everything the Buddha taught — described in the tradition as the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (the Discourse on Setting the Wheel of the Dharma in Motion), delivered to his five former ascetic companions at the Deer Park near Varanasi shortly after his awakening. They are presented as a physician's diagnosis: the symptom, the cause, the prognosis, and the treatment.

THE FIRST NOBLE TRUTH — DUKKHA (■): THE NATURE OF SUFFERING

Dukkha is often translated as 'suffering' but the full scope of the Pali word is broader and more precise than that translation suggests. Dukkha includes obvious suffering — pain, illness, loss, death. It also includes the subtler dukkha of impermanence — the fact that even pleasant experiences end, that what we love does not last, that change is constant and our resistance to change produces suffering. And it includes the deepest dukkha — the existential unsatisfactoriness that pervades conditioned existence itself, the background sense that something is fundamentally not right that no amount of worldly success or pleasure can permanently resolve. The First Noble Truth is not pessimism. It is diagnosis. The doctor who tells you that you are ill is not being pessimistic — they are being honest, which is the first requirement for treatment.

THE SECOND NOBLE TRUTH — SAMUDAYA (■): THE ORIGIN OF SUFFERING

The origin of suffering is tanha (craving, thirst) — specifically three types of craving: craving for sensual pleasure (kama-tanha), craving for existence and becoming (bhava-tanha), and craving for non-existence (vibhava-tanha). Craving arises from the fundamental misunderstanding of reality — the belief that there is a permanent, separate self that requires specific conditions to be satisfied. Because there is no such permanent self, the craving is based on a false premise and can never be permanently satisfied — which is why satisfaction always requires more satisfaction.

THE THIRD NOBLE TRUTH — NIRODHA (■): THE CESSATION OF SUFFERING

The cessation of suffering is possible. This is the prognosis — the good news after the diagnosis. When craving ceases, suffering ceases. The state of the complete cessation of craving and its associated suffering is called Nirvana (Pali: Nibbana) — literally 'blowing out,' as a candle flame is blown out. What is blown out is not the person but the fire of craving that consumed them. Nirvana is not described by the

Buddha as non-existence — it is described as beyond the categories of existence and non-existence, beyond what words can capture.

THE FOURTH NOBLE TRUTH — MAGGA (■): THE PATH TO THE CESSATION

The path that leads to the cessation of suffering is the Noble Eightfold Path — a complete framework for reorganizing every dimension of human life — understanding, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, and meditation — around the aim of liberation from the craving that produces suffering. The Eightfold Path is covered in full in the following section.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Four Noble Truths are the most clinically precise account of psychological suffering and its resolution produced by any ancient tradition. Modern cognitive therapy — particularly Acceptance and Commitment Therapy and Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy — is essentially a secular restatement of the First and Second Noble Truths: that suffering arises from the relationship between events and the mind's response to them, not from the events themselves. The Buddha identified this 2,500 years before modern psychology existed.

THE NOBLE EIGHTFOLD PATH — THE COMPLETE MAP

The Noble Eightfold Path (Ariyo Atthangiko Maggo) is organized into three categories — Wisdom (Prajna), Ethics (Sila), and Meditation (Samadhi) — that together constitute a complete transformation of every dimension of human life. The eight factors are not sequential steps but simultaneous dimensions of practice that support and deepen each other.

WISDOM (PRAJNA)

Right Understanding (Samma Ditthi)

Seeing things as they actually are — understanding the Four Noble Truths, the nature of impermanence, the nature of dependent origination, the absence of a permanent self. Right Understanding is both the beginning of the path (the intellectual understanding that motivates practice) and its fruition (the direct seeing that characterizes awakening).

Right Intention (Samma Sankappa)

The intention to renounce sensual craving, to cultivate goodwill rather than ill-will, and to cultivate harmlessness rather than cruelty. Right Intention is the motivational foundation from which ethical action and meditative practice naturally emerge.

ETHICS (SILA)

Right Speech (Samma Vaca)

Speaking truthfully, kindly, helpfully, and at the right time. Abstaining from lying, divisive speech, harsh speech, and idle chatter. Right Speech recognizes that language is one of the most powerful forces a human being wields — it creates realities, damages relationships, and either builds or destroys community.

Right Action (Samma Kammanta)

Abstaining from taking life, from taking what is not given, and from sexual misconduct. The ethical foundation of Buddhist practice — recognizing that our actions in the world have consequences that shape both our own consciousness and the wellbeing of others.

Right Livelihood (Samma Ajiva)

Earning one's living in a way that does not cause harm — abstaining from trading in weapons, living beings, meat, intoxicants, and poisons. The recognition that how we spend the majority of our waking

hours is a spiritual matter, not merely an economic one.

MEDITATION (SAMADHI)

Right Effort (Samma Vayama)

The effort to prevent unwholesome states from arising, to abandon those that have arisen, to cultivate wholesome states, and to maintain those that have arisen. Right Effort is the sustained energetic engagement with practice — not passive waiting but active cultivation.

Right Mindfulness (Samma Sati)

The sustained, non-judgmental awareness of the body, of feelings, of mental states, and of mental objects as they arise, persist, and pass away. Right Mindfulness is the foundational meditation practice of Buddhism — the specific quality of attention that allows the practitioner to see the three marks of existence (impermanence, suffering, no-self) directly in their own experience.

Right Concentration (Samma Samadhi)

The development of the four jhanas — progressive states of deepening meditative absorption characterized by increasing stillness, equanimity, and clarity. Right Concentration is the cultivation of the meditative depth from which the direct investigation of reality that leads to liberation becomes possible.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: The Noble Eightfold Path covers every dimension of the Tetralty simultaneously. Right Understanding and Right Intention are the Thinking dimension. Right Speech is the Speaking dimension. Right Action and Right Livelihood are the Doing dimension. Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, and Right Concentration are the Feeling/Being dimension. Buddhism arrived at the same four-dimensional understanding of conscious human action that the Haligric framework formalizes as the Tetralty — through a completely different route.**

The Three Marks of Existence (Tilakkhana) are the three fundamental characteristics of all conditioned phenomena that the Buddha identified as the source of both suffering and liberation — suffering when misunderstood, liberation when seen clearly.

ANICCA — IMPERMANENCE

Everything that arises passes away. Every sensation, every thought, every emotion, every relationship, every body, every civilization arises through specific conditions and passes away when those conditions change. Nothing in the conditioned world is permanent, fixed, or unchanging. This is not a philosophical position — the Buddha presents it as a directly observable fact available to any practitioner who sits still and watches their own experience with enough precision. The suffering that Anicca produces is not in the impermanence itself but in the mind's resistance to impermanence — its insistence that what it loves should stay, that what brings pleasure should continue, that what it has built should not crumble. When the mind releases this insistence and allows impermanence to be what it is — the same impermanence that was the source of suffering becomes the source of liberation.

DUKKHA — UNSATISFACTORINESS

As discussed in the First Noble Truth — the quality of dukkha permeates conditioned existence not only as obvious suffering but as the subtle unsatisfactoriness that even the most pleasant experiences carry because they are impermanent. The Buddhist analysis of dukkha is not that life is bad but that clinging to conditioned phenomena as if they were permanent sources of lasting satisfaction is systematically mistaken — and that recognizing this mistake is the beginning of genuine freedom.

ANATMAN — NO PERMANENT SELF

The most radical and most widely misunderstood of the three marks. Anatman (Pali: Anatta) is the teaching that there is no permanent, unchanging, independent self or soul. This does not mean there is no person, no experience, no continuity of character — it means that what we take to be the 'self' is actually a dynamic process, a flowing river rather than a fixed stone, a constellation of constantly changing physical and mental processes rather than a unitary unchanging entity. The Buddhist analysis identifies five aggregates (skandhas) that together constitute what we experience as 'self': form (the body), sensation (pleasant/unpleasant/neutral), perception (recognition), mental formations (emotions, intentions, attention), and consciousness (awareness). None of these individually is the self; none of their combination is the self; but the interaction of the five produces the experience of selfhood. When this is seen directly — not just intellectually understood but directly perceived in meditative investigation — the

clinging to self that produces suffering is profoundly loosened.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Anatman teaching is the point where Buddhism and Advaita Vedanta appear most different while actually being closest. Vedanta teaches Atman IS Brahman — the true self is the infinite divine. Buddhism teaches there is no self as ordinarily conceived. Both are pointing at the same recognition from different directions: the small, separate, defended self that suffers is not the fundamental reality. What remains when that self is seen through is what both traditions are gesturing at — one calling it the infinite Self, the other calling it the unconditioned, the deathless, Nirvana.

Pratityasamutpada (Pali: Patīccasamuppāda) — Dependent Origination — is the Buddha's account of how suffering arises and how it ceases. It is presented as a chain of twelve links, each arising in dependence on the previous one and ceasing when the previous one ceases. The chain runs in both directions: forward as the arising of suffering, backward as the path of liberation.

The twelve links are: Ignorance (avidyā) conditions Mental Formations (saṃskāra), which condition Consciousness (vijñāna), which conditions Name-and-Form (nāmarūpa), which conditions the Six Sense Bases (saḍāyatana), which condition Contact (sparśa), which conditions Feeling-Tone (vedāna), which conditions Craving (tanhā), which conditions Clinging (upādāna), which conditions Becoming (bhava), which conditions Birth (jāti), which conditions Aging-and-Death (jaramarana).

The key insight is that ignorance — specifically the ignorance of the three marks of existence, the misunderstanding of impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and no-self — is the first link in the chain. This means that suffering is not a random accident or a divine punishment. It arises from a specific, identifiable cause that can be understood and addressed. And when that cause — ignorance — is replaced by its opposite, wisdom, the entire chain ceases: no ignorance, no mental formations conditioning consciousness toward craving; no craving, no clinging; no clinging, no becoming; no becoming, no birth into the conditioned world of suffering.

"When this exists, that comes to be.

With the arising of this, that arises.

When this does not exist, that does not come to be.

With the cessation of this, that ceases."

— The Buddha, on Dependent Origination

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Dependent Origination is the earliest systematic statement of what modern systems theory calls emergence — the recognition that nothing exists independently, that everything arises in relationship to everything else, and that changing any element of the system changes the entire system. It is also the cosmological foundation of the Haligric understanding that the universe is a living interconnected whole — not a collection of separate objects but a web of mutually conditioning relationships in which nothing is truly isolated.

After his awakening, the Buddha initially hesitated to teach — doubting that what he had understood could be communicated to beings still deeply embedded in craving and delusion. The tradition describes the deity Brahma Sahampati appearing and imploring him to teach, pointing out that while many would not understand, there were 'beings with little dust in their eyes' who would benefit from hearing the Dharma.

He went to the Deer Park at Isipatana (present-day Sarnath) near Varanasi and taught the Five Ascetics who had previously abandoned him when he gave up extreme asceticism. They became the first five monks — the beginning of the Sangha (community). The Three Jewels — Buddha, Dharma (teaching), and Sangha (community) — were now established, and the tradition of 'taking refuge' in the Three Jewels became the foundational act of becoming a Buddhist.

The early Sangha grew rapidly. Within a year of the first teaching, the tradition records sixty fully awakened disciples sent out in sixty different directions to teach 'for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world.' The Buddha spent approximately forty-five years walking across the Ganges plain — from Bodh Gaya in the west to Vaishali in the northeast — teaching, establishing communities, and engaging with kings, merchants, outcasts, women, and intellectuals with equal accessibility.

Women were initially excluded from full ordination — the Buddha's hesitation on this point is one of the most discussed passages in early Buddhist texts. His foster mother Mahaprajapati eventually petitioned for women's ordination three times, and the Buddha finally agreed — with the addition of eight special rules (garudhamma) placing nuns subordinate to monks regardless of seniority. The ordination of women made Buddhism the first major world religion to formally establish a female monastic community, though the subordinate position of that community remains contested in contemporary Buddhism.

THE BUDDHIST COUNCILS AND THE SPLIT INTO SCHOOLS

After the Buddha's death (Parinirvana) at approximately eighty years of age in Kushinagar, his disciples convened the First Buddhist Council at Rajagriha to recite and compile the teachings. The monk Ananda — the Buddha's personal attendant who had memorized everything he heard — recited the discourses (suttas). The monk Upali recited the monastic rules (Vinaya). The collective verification of both became the foundation of the Pali Canon.

The Second Council, approximately one hundred years after the Buddha's death, addressed disputes about monastic rules — specifically whether ten practices that some monks had adopted were permissible. The council ruled against these practices, but the monks who supported them did not accept the ruling. This dispute is traditionally identified as the beginning of the split between the Sthaviravada (Way of the Elders, later becoming Theravada) and the Mahasanghika (Great Community) — which would eventually develop into the Mahayana tradition.

The Third Council under Emperor Ashoka (approximately 250 BCE) was a watershed moment. Ashoka — who had converted to Buddhism after witnessing the carnage of a military campaign — became the most powerful Buddhist patron in history, sending missionary delegations in all directions. His son Mahinda brought Buddhism to Sri Lanka, where the Theravada tradition has been preserved in its most complete form. His emissaries reached Egypt, Greece, Syria, and Central Asia — setting in motion the spread of Buddhism that would eventually reach every inhabited continent.

Theravada (Way of the Elders) is the oldest surviving Buddhist school and the dominant tradition in Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand, Laos, and Cambodia. It preserves the Pali Canon — the most complete early Buddhist textual collection — and understands itself as preserving the original teaching of the Buddha most faithfully.

Theravada's central aspiration is the Arahant — the fully awakened person who has completely eliminated all defilements and will not be reborn after death. The Arahant's awakening is complete and final: at death, the five aggregates that constitute the person dissolve and are not reconstituted. This is Nirvana — the complete cessation of conditioned existence. The Theravada path is fundamentally a monastic path — while lay practice is honored and meritorious, full awakening is understood to be most accessible to those who have renounced household life.

Theravada meditation practice is centered on Vipassana (insight meditation) — the systematic investigation of the three marks of existence in one's direct experience through sustained mindfulness — and Samatha (calm abiding) — the development of meditative concentration and the jhana states. The contemporary mindfulness movement in Western psychology, medicine, and corporate culture is almost entirely derived from Theravada Vipassana practice, particularly the lineage of Mahasi Sayadaw and U Ba Khin transmitted by S.N. Goenka.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: Theravada's gift to the Haligric framework is the most precise and most systematically developed mindfulness technology in any tradition. The Satipatthana Sutta (Foundations of Mindfulness) — the primary Theravada mindfulness text — is a complete manual for the investigation of body, feeling, mind, and mental objects with the sustained non-judgmental awareness that reveals their actual nature. This is the Feeling dimension of the Tetralty developed to its highest possible precision.**

THE PALI CANON — THE TIPITAKA

The Pali Canon (Tipitaka — Three Baskets) is the most complete early Buddhist textual collection and is considered the authoritative scriptural source in Theravada Buddhism. It is called the Three Baskets because it is organized into three major divisions.

THE VINAYA PITAKA — BASKET OF DISCIPLINE

The monastic code — the rules governing the behavior of monks (Bhikkhus) and nuns (Bhikkhunis), the procedures for monastic ceremonies, and the stories explaining how each rule came to be established. The Bhikkhu Patimokkha contains 227 rules for monks; the Bhikkhuni Patimokkha contains 311 rules for nuns. The Vinaya is the living constitution of the Buddhist monastic community and has been in continuous use for 2,500 years.

THE SUTTA PITAKA — BASKET OF DISCOURSES

The largest division — containing thousands of discourses attributed to the Buddha and his senior disciples, organized into five collections (Nikayas). The Digha Nikaya (Long Discourses), the Majjhima Nikaya (Middle Length Discourses), the Samyutta Nikaya (Connected Discourses), the Anguttara Nikaya (Numerical Discourses), and the Khuddaka Nikaya (Minor Works — including the Dhammapada, the Jataka tales, and the Sutta Nipata). These texts represent the most extensive collection of discourses attributed to any ancient teacher.

THE ABHIDHAMMA PITAKA — BASKET OF HIGHER TEACHING

The philosophical and psychological analysis of the mind and reality — the most technically demanding part of the Pali Canon. The Abhidhamma analyzes experience into its irreducible constituents (dhammas), maps the arising and passing of mental states in extraordinary detail, and provides the philosophical foundation for Buddhist psychology. Modern Buddhist-influenced psychology draws heavily from Abhidhamma analysis of mind.

Mahayana (Great Vehicle) emerged as a distinct movement within Buddhism approximately in the 1st century BCE to 1st century CE — though its precise origins remain debated. The name Mahayana was adopted partly in contrast to what Mahayana texts called the Hinayana (Lesser Vehicle) — a polemical name for the earlier schools that Theravada understandably rejects. The core distinction between Mahayana and earlier Buddhism is not primarily philosophical but motivational: the Mahayana practitioner aspires not only to their own liberation but to the liberation of all sentient beings.

Mahayana developed an enormous body of new scriptures — the Mahayana sutras — that are not found in the Pali Canon and that Mahayana Buddhism understands as the deeper teaching of the Buddha preserved in non-human realms until humanity was ready to receive them. Theravada Buddhism does not accept these texts as the Buddha's word. The debate about their authority shaped Buddhist history for centuries and remains unresolved between the traditions.

Mahayana spread from India along the Silk Road into Central Asia and then into China (1st-2nd century CE), Korea (4th century CE), Japan (6th century CE), and Vietnam (2nd century CE). It is the dominant form of Buddhism in East Asia and is practiced by the majority of the world's Buddhists.

The Bodhisattva (Sanskrit: enlightenment-being) is the central figure of Mahayana Buddhism — a being who has vowed to attain full Buddhahood for the benefit of all sentient beings, and who postpones their own final Nirvana until every sentient being has been liberated. The Bodhisattva ideal represents one of the most radical expressions of compassion as a spiritual path produced by any tradition.

The Bodhisattva vow is made in the presence of the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas of all directions and times: 'However innumerable sentient beings are, I vow to save them all. However inexhaustible the defilements are, I vow to extinguish them all. However immeasurable the Dharmas are, I vow to master them all. However incomparable the Buddha-Way is, I vow to attain it.' This is understood not as a single lifetime commitment but as a vow across countless lifetimes — the Bodhisattva path spans eons of compassionate activity before complete Buddhahood is achieved.

The six Paramitas (Perfections) are the qualities the Bodhisattva cultivates across innumerable lifetimes: Dana (generosity), Sila (ethics), Kshanti (patience), Virya (energy/diligence), Dhyana (meditation), and Prajna (wisdom). Each paramita is practiced not for the Bodhisattva's own benefit but for the benefit of all beings.

The great Bodhisattvas — Avalokiteshvara (Guanyin in China, Kannon in Japan — the Bodhisattva of compassion who hears the cries of all beings), Manjushri (wisdom), Samantabhadra (action), Ksitigarbha (who works in hell realms for those who suffer most) — became the objects of devotion for millions of East Asian Buddhists and introduced a devotional, relational dimension to Buddhist practice that had been less prominent in the earlier tradition.

♦ HALIGRIC LENS: Avalokiteshvara — the Bodhisattva of compassion who takes any form necessary to reach suffering beings — is one of the most significant divine feminine figures in world religion. In China, Avalokiteshvara transformed from a male figure into the female Guanyin — Goddess of Mercy — becoming one of the most widely venerated sacred figures in East Asian civilization. The suppressed divine feminine of Buddhism found her way back, as she always does, through the door of compassion.

Sunyata (Sanskrit: emptiness, voidness) is the central philosophical concept of Mahayana Buddhism and one of the most radical and most frequently misunderstood ideas in any philosophical tradition. It was systematically developed by Nagarjuna (approximately 2nd century CE) in the *Mulamadhyamakakarika* (Root Verses on the Middle Way) — one of the most rigorous philosophical texts ever written.

Sunyata does not mean that nothing exists or that reality is nothing. It means that no phenomenon — including the self, including the Buddha, including Nirvana itself — has *svabhava*: own-being, inherent independent existence. Everything that exists exists in dependence on other things, arising through conditions, and is therefore empty of the kind of fixed, independent, self-sufficient being that ordinary consciousness assumes things to have.

The *Prajna Paramita* (Perfection of Wisdom) texts — including the Heart Sutra, one of the shortest and most recited texts in all of Buddhism — are the scriptural source for the Sunyata teaching. The Heart Sutra's most famous statement — 'Form is emptiness, emptiness is form' — is not a paradox or a mystery but a precise philosophical claim: what appears as solid, fixed form is actually a dynamic, interdependent process empty of fixed self-existence; and that emptiness is not a void but the very condition that allows form to appear, change, and function.

*"Form is emptiness, emptiness is form.
Emptiness is not other than form;
form is not other than emptiness."*

— Heart Sutra (Prajna Paramita Hridaya)

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: Sunyata and Brahman are not the same — but they point in the same direction from different philosophical starting points. Vedanta says: the ultimate reality is the infinite self-luminous consciousness that underlies all appearance. Buddhism says: no phenomenon has fixed independent existence; all is interdependent. Both are undermining the same fundamental mistake — the belief in solid, separate, fixed entities — and pointing toward the same recognition of reality's fluid, relational, co-arising nature.**

BUDDHA-NATURE — THE SEED OF AWAKENING IN EVERY BEING

The Tathagatagarbha (Womb/Embryo of the Thus-Gone One) teaching holds that every sentient being possesses Buddha-nature — an inherent seed or potential for awakening that is the deepest reality of their being. This teaching emerges in the Tathagatagarbha sutras and the Nirvana Sutra and represents one of the most Haligric teachings in the entire Buddhist canon.

Buddha-nature is not something to be achieved or acquired — it is already present. The path of practice is not the construction of something new but the removal of what obscures what was always already there: the defilements, the wrong views, the habitual patterns of mind that function like clouds covering the sun. The sun has not gone anywhere. The practice clears the clouds.

The Zen tradition's expression of this teaching is particularly direct: 'What is Buddha-nature? Your original face before your parents were born.' The Dzogchen tradition of Tibetan Buddhism calls it rigpa — the primordially pure, spontaneously perfect awareness that is the nature of mind itself. The Pure Land tradition understands the recitation of Amitabha's name as an invocation of the Buddha-nature that is already present — calling it forth rather than importing something from outside.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: Buddha-nature is the Buddhist name for the Haligric recognition that the divine does not live above the human being waiting to be appeased — it lives AS the human being, waiting to be recognized. You are not seeking awakening. You are awakening seeking itself. The one who looks and the one who is looked for are not two things. This is Atman = Brahman in Buddhist vocabulary.**

Mahayana Buddhism produced several major distinct schools across its spread through Asia, each emphasizing different aspects of the vast Mahayana teaching while sharing the Bodhisattva ideal and the Sunyata philosophical foundation.

PURE LAND (JINGTU) — CHINA, JAPAN, KOREA, VIETNAM

Pure Land Buddhism centers on devotion to Amitabha Buddha — the Buddha of Infinite Light who presides over the Western Pure Land (Sukhavati) — and on the practice of nembutsu (Japanese) or nianfo (Chinese): the recitation of Amitabha's name with sincere faith and one-pointed mind. This practice is understood to ensure rebirth in the Pure Land — a realm of perfect conditions for the swift attainment of awakening. Pure Land is the most widely practiced form of Buddhism in East Asia, particularly in Japan, where the Jodo Shu and Jodo Shinshu schools have tens of millions of adherents. The Jodo Shinshu teacher Shinran (1173-1263 CE) radicalized the teaching further — teaching that it is not the practitioner's own effort or worthiness that enables liberation but entirely Amitabha's grace (tariki — Other Power).

ZEN/CHAN — CHINA, JAPAN, KOREA, VIETNAM

Chan (China) / Zen (Japan) / Seon (Korea) / Thien (Vietnam) — the tradition of sudden awakening transmitted 'outside the scriptures, beyond words and letters, pointing directly to the mind.' Zen traces its lineage to the Indian monk Bodhidharma who came to China in approximately 520 CE and to his teaching that awakening is a direct recognition, not a gradual accumulation. The two primary Zen schools are Rinzai (which uses koan practice — paradoxical questions designed to break the ordinary mind's categories and provoke direct seeing) and Soto (which emphasizes shikantaza — just sitting, the complete wholehearted practice of zazen without any goal). Zen has had the most significant impact on Western culture of any Buddhist school — influencing art, poetry, psychotherapy, and contemporary mindfulness.

TIANTAI — CHINA, JAPAN (AS TENDAI)

Founded by Zhiyi (538-597 CE), Tiantai is one of the most philosophically sophisticated schools in all of Buddhism. Its central teaching — the three truths (emptiness, conventional existence, and the middle) as simultaneously present in every phenomenon — is a remarkable synthesis of Sunyata philosophy with an affirmation of conventional reality's validity. Tiantai also developed the most comprehensive classification of Buddhist teachings in Chinese Buddhism — organizing the entire body of Buddhist

scripture into a hierarchical system with the Lotus Sutra at the apex.

HUAYAN — CHINA, JAPAN (AS KEGON)

Huayan takes its name from the Avatamsaka (Flower Garland) Sutra and develops the most complete philosophical expression of interdependence in Buddhist thought: the Indra's Net metaphor — an infinite net in which every node contains a jewel that reflects every other jewel, which in turn reflects every other jewel, infinitely — is the Huayan image for the mutual interpenetration of all phenomena. Everything contains everything. This is dependent origination understood not merely as causal sequence but as simultaneous mutual constitution.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: Indra's Net — the Huayan image of every jewel reflecting every other jewel infinitely — is the single most precise cosmological image for the Haligric understanding of interconnectedness. The circle of the Haligric symbol — the interconnectedness of all things — is Indra's Net understood as a sacred symbol. Every point in the net is the center. Every jewel contains all the others. You are not a point in the net. You are the net, appearing as a point.**

Vajrayana (Diamond Vehicle, also called Tantric Buddhism or Mantrayana) is the third major vehicle of Buddhist practice, emerging in India approximately in the 5th-7th centuries CE and spreading to Tibet, Nepal, Mongolia, and (via China) to Japan in the form of Shingon. It is called the Diamond Vehicle because the vajra (diamond scepter/thunderbolt) is both indestructible and capable of cutting through everything — representing the quality of awakened awareness that cannot be obscured and that cuts through all delusion.

Vajrayana accepts the philosophical foundation of Mahayana — Sunyata, Buddha-nature, the Bodhisattva ideal — but adds a radically accelerated path to awakening through the use of skillful means (upaya): the transformation of ordinary experience into sacred experience through specific ritual technologies. These technologies — which include deity visualization (sadhana), mantra, mudra, mandala, and the direct transmission of awakening from teacher to student (initiation/empowerment) — are understood to make possible in a single lifetime what the Mahayana Bodhisattva path requires countless lifetimes to achieve.

The distinctive Vajrayana teaching is the transformation of the five poisons (ignorance, attachment, aversion, pride, jealousy) into the five wisdoms — rather than the gradual elimination of the defilements (the Theravada approach) or the recognition of their emptiness (the Mahayana approach). Vajrayana says: the poison itself, directly recognized, is the medicine. The energy of anger, directly seen in its nature, is the mirror-like wisdom that perceives reality without distortion. The energy of desire, directly seen, is the discriminating wisdom that perceives uniqueness and particularity. The transformation is not suppression or transcendence but recognition.

A dedicated deep dive on Tibetan Vajrayana Buddhism and Bon is the companion document to this overview. Japanese Shingon Buddhism — which preserved the most complete Tantric transmission from 8th-century India in the East Asian world — is the second companion document.

❖ HALIGRIC LENS: The Vajrayana transformation of poison into wisdom is one of the most radical and most Haligric teachings in any tradition. It does not ask the practitioner to eliminate their anger, desire, or pride — it asks them to look at the energy directly and recognize what it actually is beneath the story it tells about itself. This is the alchemy. Not suppression. Not transcendence. Recognition. The energy that drives suffering, directly seen, is the energy of awakening.

THE SPREAD OF BUDDHISM ACROSS ASIA

Buddhism's spread across Asia over twenty-five centuries is one of the most extraordinary cultural transmission stories in human history — accomplished entirely through persuasion, patronage, and the quality of practice, without a single military campaign conducted in Buddhism's name.

REGION	PERIOD	KEY DEVELOPMENT
SRI LANKA	3rd century BCE	Emperor Ashoka's son Mahinda brought Theravada Buddhism to Sri Lanka — where it has been a state religion since 1971.
CHINA	1st-2nd century CE	Buddhism entered China along the Silk Road — first reaching the cosmopolitan trading city of Guangzhou.
KOREA	4th century CE	Buddhism entered Korea from China during the Three Kingdoms period and became the state religion in 527 CE.
JAPAN	6th century CE	Buddhism arrived in Japan from Korea in 552 CE (traditional date) or 538 CE — brought as a state religion.
TIBET	7th century CE	Buddhism entered Tibet during the reign of King Songtsen Gampo and was dramatically expanded by the 13th century.
SOUTHEAST ASIA	Various periods	Thailand, Myanmar, Cambodia, Laos — Theravada Buddhism became the state religion of these regions.

Buddhism's spread in China was not uncontested. The tradition faced significant persecution during four periods — the 'Three Wu and One Zong' persecutions (san wu yi zong) — in which ruling emperors suppressed Buddhism for political and economic reasons. The most devastating was the Huichang Suppression (840-845 CE) under Emperor Tang Wuzong, who was a devoted Taoist and viewed Buddhism as a foreign drain on Chinese economic and cultural resources.

In five years of suppression, Emperor Wuzong ordered the destruction of over 40,000 Buddhist temples and shrines, the forced laicization of over 260,000 monks and nuns, the confiscation of temple lands, and the melting down of bronze Buddhist statues for their metal. The destruction was so thorough that the most elaborate Chinese Buddhist traditions — particularly the Huayan and Tiantai schools, which required extensive monastic institutions to maintain their complex philosophical and ritual traditions — never fully recovered.

The traditions that survived most fully were those that could be maintained without elaborate institutional support — Chan (Zen), which emphasized direct mind-to-mind transmission between teacher and student requiring minimal institutional infrastructure, and Pure Land, which required only sincere faith and the recitation of Amitabha's name. This is why Chan and Pure Land became the dominant Chinese Buddhist traditions after the Tang dynasty — not because they were philosophically superior but because they were structurally resilient to persecution.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: The Huichang Suppression is the Chinese Buddhist equivalent of what Roman Christianity did to every indigenous tradition it encountered — the institutional destruction of a sacred tradition for political and economic reasons. The Haligric recognition across all suppressed traditions is the same: what cannot be destroyed is the direct recognition that requires no institution to preserve it. The Zen tradition survived precisely because it never put its essential transmission in a building.**

Buddhism began reaching the West in significant numbers in the late 19th century through several simultaneous channels: the Theosophical Society (which Helena Blavatsky and Henry Steel Olcott explicitly identified as aligned with Buddhist principles), the 1893 World's Parliament of Religions in Chicago (where the Sri Lankan monk Anagarika Dharmapala and the Japanese Rinzai Zen master Soyen Shaku made lasting impressions on Western audiences), and the scholarly translation of Buddhist texts into European languages by figures like T.W. Rhys Davids and Max Muller.

The 20th century brought successive waves of Buddhist influence to the West: D.T. Suzuki's prolific English-language writing on Zen reaching American intellectuals in the 1950s (influencing the Beat Generation — Kerouac, Ginsberg, Snyder); the Tibetan diaspora following China's 1959 occupation of Tibet bringing Vajrayana teachers to the West; the Vipassana teachers like Mahasi Sayadaw's students Jack Kornfield and Joseph Goldstein establishing insight meditation communities; and the mindfulness movement pioneered by Jon Kabat-Zinn making Buddhist meditation practices available to a secular Western audience in medical and psychological contexts.

Western Buddhism has developed its own characteristics: a tendency toward greater gender equality than traditional Asian Buddhism (with women increasingly receiving full ordination and teaching authority), a strong emphasis on lay practice rather than monasticism, integration with Western psychology (the dialogue between Buddhism and psychotherapy is one of the most productive in contemporary spiritual life), and a tendency toward engagement with social and environmental justice as expressions of Buddhist compassion (Engaged Buddhism, pioneered by Thich Nhat Hanh).

THE MAJOR BUDDHIST TEXTS

The Buddhist textual tradition is one of the largest bodies of sacred literature in the world — the Tibetan Buddhist canon alone contains over 300 volumes. What follows are the most significant texts for the Haligric library's purposes.

THE DHAMMAPADA

The most widely read text in all of Theravada Buddhism — 423 verses attributed to the Buddha covering the entire range of Buddhist teaching in compressed, memorable form. Its opening lines are among the most famous in all of Buddhist literature: 'Mind is the forerunner of all actions. All deeds are led by mind, created by mind.' A complete introduction to Buddhist ethics and psychology in poetic form.

THE HEART SUTRA (PRAJNA PARAMITA HRIDAYA)

The shortest and most recited Mahayana text — 260 characters in Chinese, chanted daily in Zen, Pure Land, Vajrayana, and other Mahayana traditions across Asia. Contains the complete teaching of Sunyata in condensed form, including the famous 'Form is emptiness, emptiness is form.'

THE LOTUS SUTRA (SADDHARMAPUNDARIKA)

One of the most important Mahayana texts in East Asian Buddhism — the scriptural foundation of the Tiantai and Nichiren schools. Its central teaching is the One Vehicle (Ekayana) — that all Buddhist paths ultimately lead to the same destination of full Buddhahood, and that the Buddha's previous teachings of different vehicles were skillful means adapted to practitioners' different capacities.

THE VIMALAKIRTI SUTRA

One of the most beloved and most literary Mahayana texts — the story of the enlightened layman Vimalakirti who defeats all the great Bodhisattvas in dharma combat. Its most famous passage is Vimalakirti's 'thunderous silence' in response to Manjushri's question about non-duality — the silence that contains more than any words could express.

THE TIBETAN BOOK OF THE DEAD (BARDO THODOL)

The most complete Buddhist guide to the process of dying, death, and rebirth — compiled by Padmasambhava and discovered as a terma (treasure text) by Karma Lingpa in the 14th century. It

describes the experiences of consciousness in the three bardos (in-between states) after death and provides specific instructions for recognizing the nature of mind at each stage. Covered in full depth in the companion Tibetan Vajrayana document.

THE PLATFORM SUTRA OF THE SIXTH PATRIARCH

The only text produced by a Chinese master that is accorded the status of a sutra in the Chan/Zen tradition — the teaching of Huineng (638-713 CE), the Sixth Patriarch of Chinese Chan. Contains the foundational teachings of sudden awakening and the famous verse competition that established Huineng's superiority over the head monk Shenxiu: 'Originally there is not a single thing — where can dust alight?'

BUDDHIST PRACTICE — MEDITATION, MANTRA, MANDALA

Buddhist practice takes different forms across the three vehicles, but certain elements appear across all traditions:

MEDITATION (BHAVANA)

The most universal Buddhist practice across all schools. Samatha (calm abiding) — developing meditative concentration and the jhana states. Vipassana (insight) — the systematic investigation of the three marks of existence in direct experience. Loving-kindness (Metta) — the systematic cultivation of goodwill toward all beings beginning with oneself. Tonglen (Tibetan) — the practice of taking in suffering and sending out relief, reversing the ordinary self-protective orientation of the mind. Zazen (Zen) — just sitting, the wholehearted practice of seated meditation without goal or attainment.

MANTRA

Sacred sound formulas used across Buddhist traditions, particularly in Vajrayana where mantra is one of the three primary practice vehicles alongside mudra and mandala. The most widely known Buddhist mantra is Om Mani Padme Hum — associated with Avalokiteshvara, the Bodhisattva of Compassion — chanted by millions of Tibetan Buddhists daily and inscribed on prayer wheels, prayer flags, and stone throughout the Himalayan Buddhist world. The Nembutsu (Namu Amida Butsu — Homage to Amitabha Buddha) is the Pure Land mantra practice — chanted as a complete path to liberation by tens of millions of East Asian Buddhists.

MANDALA

Sacred geometric diagrams representing the palace or realm of specific Buddhas or Bodhisattvas — used in Vajrayana for visualization practice, for ritual offering, and for initiation ceremonies. The Tibetan tradition of sand mandala — creating an extraordinarily detailed mandala from colored sand over days or weeks and then ritually destroying it — is one of the most visually stunning sacred art forms in any tradition and a living embodiment of the teaching on impermanence.

DANA — GENEROSITY

The foundational lay Buddhist practice across all traditions — the giving of material support to the monastic community and to those in need. Dana is not merely charity but a specific practice for loosening the grip of attachment and cultivating the recognition that giving and receiving are not separate acts but

different aspects of the same flow of abundance.

TAKING REFUGE

The foundational act of becoming a Buddhist — the formal declaration of taking refuge in the Three Jewels: Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha. This is not worship in the Western religious sense but an alignment of intention — orienting one's life toward awakening (Buddha), toward truth (Dharma), and toward community of practice (Sangha).

THE HALIGRIC LENS — WHAT BUDDHISM GOT RIGHT

Buddhism is not a tradition that Haligricity views from the outside. It is one of the deepest currents running through the Haligric synthesis — present in the Well-Being book's mindfulness and body-awareness practices, in the Rituals book's understanding of ceremony as conscious attention, in the Philosophy book's understanding of the mind's relationship to reality, and in the shouldin document's Zen and Vajrayana applications. What follows is the Haligric reading of Buddhism's specific contributions.

WHAT BUDDHISM GOT MOST PRECISELY RIGHT

The Four Noble Truths as a diagnostic framework. No tradition — not Vedanta, not Taoism, not any indigenous tradition — produced a more precise clinical account of the structure of suffering and its resolution. The mechanism is identified: craving arising from ignorance. The path is specified: the Eightfold Path. The outcome is described: the cessation of craving and its associated suffering. This is not theology. It is phenomenology — a description of what is actually happening in experience, verifiable by anyone who investigates their own mind with sufficient precision.

THE MINDFULNESS CONTRIBUTION

Buddhism gave the world's contemplative traditions their most systematically developed mindfulness technology — the Satipatthana framework of sustained non-judgmental awareness of body, feeling, mind, and mental objects. This technology is now one of the most empirically researched in all of psychology, with documented effects on stress, chronic pain, depression, anxiety, and immune function. Modern mindfulness-based clinical interventions are essentially secular Vipassana — Buddhist technology extracted from its religious container and validated by Western scientific method.

DEPENDENT ORIGATION AS SYSTEMS WISDOM

Pratityasamutpada — dependent origination — is the earliest and most complete expression of what modern systems theory, ecology, and complexity science describe mathematically: that nothing exists independently, that everything co-arises in relationship, and that changing any element of a system affects the whole system. This is not metaphor. It is a precise description of how reality is organized — one that 2,500 years of Buddhist contemplative investigation and contemporary scientific research both confirm.

THE BODHISATTVA VOW AS SACRED ETHICS

The Bodhisattva vow — to work for the liberation of all sentient beings across innumerable lifetimes — is the most expansive statement of ethical responsibility in any religious tradition. It extends concern not only to all humans but to all sentient beings across all time. Contemporary environmental ethics, animal rights philosophy, and intergenerational justice thinking are all implicit in the Bodhisattva vow.

WHAT HALIGRICITY ADDS TO WHAT BUDDHISM FOUND

Buddhism, in its most classical Theravada expression, can tend toward a relationship with the body as the vehicle of suffering rather than the vessel of the divine — the physical world as something to be transcended rather than honored. Haligrity brings the Yoruba understanding of Ashe — the divine creative force moving through all physical matter — and the Aboriginal understanding of Country as living sacred presence to the conversation. The body is not the problem. It is the instrument. The world is not the obstacle. It is the teaching. The Vajrayana tradition within Buddhism arrives at the same recognition — but Haligrity holds it as the starting point rather than the advanced attainment.

*"Just as a candle cannot burn without fire,
men cannot live without a spiritual life."*

*"In the sky, there is no distinction of east and west;
people create distinctions out of their own minds
and then believe them to be true."*

"Peace comes from within. Do not seek it without."

— Teachings attributed to the Buddha

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Buddha left his palace and sat under a tree. What he found there was not imported from anywhere — it was the nature of his own mind, which had always been present and had never been other than what it was. He spent forty-five years pointing at it from every possible angle. Two and a half thousand years later, the pointing continues — in Zen monasteries and Vipassana centers and Tibetan retreat caves and California mindfulness apps and Haligrity Well-Being books. The finger changes. The moon it points at does not. Grand Rising.

Companion documents: Tibetan Vajrayana Buddhism and Bon | Japanese Shingon Buddhism